



RESILIENCE: After Partition, India fought off fissiparous forces with relative ease

up in converting their territory into sacred soil. Like *sankhya*, it is better in such cases to begin with an analysis of the effects and not the cause. If we use the effects test then India comes up on top as a successful nation-state. Our wars with Pakistan and China have sacralised our territory repeatedly. When we have border tensions we come together regardless of political differences. When India helped in dismembering Pakistan, leading to the creation of Bangladesh, even CPI(M) parliamentarians boisterously broke protocol and decorum right under the Speaker's dais.

Today, if any political party is to be put in the doghouse, the best ploy is to characterise it as an anti-national, secessionist organisation. This is how the Shiv Sena and the BJP characterise their opponents. This is also how the Congress demonised the Akali Dal in the 1980s; and this is also why we lost potential allies in Kashmir. While this appeal to emotion has a fairly good track record in terms of whipping up passions based on blood and soil, it does little good for the cause of citizens who fall between the cracks. Minorities get further marginalised and persecuted and, what is worse, one never knows who the next minority will be. The Sikhs, for example, had no idea that they were actually minorities till 1984 happened.

Clearly, we have a strong nationalist sentiment in India, but that, in my view is not enough. We need to foster a sense of citizenship and that is the crucial test that lies ahead. The debates should no longer be about India's unity. India has proved itself and shown its detractors to be wrong for 60 straight years. We now have

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to prove ourselves as a nation-state that respects "citizens" and not just "people". There are no majorities and minorities, no insiders and outsiders. The rich and poor have equal rights as citizens as they can access public goods at quality levels regardless of the accident of birth. When that happens India will be democratic in truly substantive terms.

Can we overcome our national grief and look beyond Pakistan and the Partition? Perhaps we can, though not yet. Once that happens, a new alignment of forces will have to be in place. In this fresh configuration we will not be arguing about nation-states any longer but about "knowledge-states". The European Union is haltingly showing us the way in this regard, but we have still a long way to go even there.

But when we finally reach that destination it will be a huge relief. We can, at long last, finally rid ourselves of the savage histories of our collective pasts that nation-states find so inspirational.



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